

Qroo Paul's Spanish Master Course

Lesson 20 Summary

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In this lesson, we cover the *personal a*—one of those little quirks in Spanish that confuses English speakers because we don't have an equivalent in English and it often doesn't translate.

What is the Personal "A"?

The *personal a* is the letter **a** used when the **direct object** of a verb refers to a person or a pet. You're not translating it into English—it's simply required in Spanish.

Example:

Veo a Juan.

(I see Juan.)

We use **a** because Juan is a person and the object of the sentence.

Try this one:

Veo a María.

(I see María.)

Even plural people still require the *personal a*:

Veo a los hombres.

(I see the men.)

Pets Get Special Treatment

Veo a mi perro.

(I see my dog.)

We use *a* because pets are treated like people in Spanish.

But no *personal a* for other animals:

Veo dos delfines.

(I see two dolphins.)

No Personal A for Inanimate Objects

Veo las casas.

(I see the houses.)

Veo la playa.

(I see the beach.)

Distinguishing the Personal A from Other Uses of “A”

Sometimes a sentence has multiple **a**’s, but only one is the *personal a*. Consider:

Voy a invitar a mi hermano a la fiesta.
(I’m going to invite my brother to the party.)

Breakdown:

- **a invitar** – part of *ir a + infinitive*
- **a mi hermano** – *this* is the *personal a* (brother is the direct object)
- **a la fiesta** – preposition meaning “to the party”

Learn Verbs with Prepositions

Some verbs, like *invitar*, naturally pair with **a**. Learn them that way:

Invitar a – to invite someone

Invitar a + infinitive – to invite someone to do something

When the Personal A Is Optional or Omitted

With certain verbs—like *buscar* (to look for), *encontrar* (to find), *necesitar* (to need), and *contratar* (to hire)—you might not see the personal **a** when referring to **non-specific** people.

Examples (non-specific):

Buscamos un profesor.

(We’re looking for a professor.)

Necesitamos empleados.

(We need employees.)

Quiero contratar una secretaria.

(I want to hire a secretary.)

Examples (specific):

Buscamos a un profesor que conocemos.

(We’re looking for a professor we know.)

Necesitamos a los empleados que conocen el sistema.

(We need the employees who know the system.)

If the person or group is **specific**, you must use the *personal a*.

Words Like “Someone,” “No One,” and “Anyone”

Even though they aren’t named people, the *personal a* usually appears before:

- alguien (someone/anyone)
- nadie (no one)

Examples:

¿Conoces a alguien que sepa cocinar?
(Do you know someone who knows how to cook?)
No conozco a nadie que sepa cocinar.
(I don't know anyone who knows how to cook.)

(Note: *sepa* is the subjunctive form of *saber*, “to know.”)

The Verb “Tener” (to have) – No Personal A

Although we're often talking about people or pets, when using *tener*, we **don't** use the personal *a*:

Tengo dos hijos.
(I have two children.)
Tengo una esposa.
(I have a wife.)
Tengo un perro.
(I have a dog.)

There are rare exceptions where *tener* takes the personal *a*, but they change the meaning slightly, often to something like “I have someone in a role.”

Example:

Tengo a mi tío como garante.
(I have my uncle as a guarantor.)

Closing

And that's your introduction to the personal *a*. While it might seem tricky at first, it follows clear patterns and becomes natural with practice. You'll see it often as you move forward in Spanish, and over time, it will feel automatic.

Ready to test your skills?

An exercise for this lesson is available in the next section.

Hasta luego.